

SETTING NEW PARADIGMS IN ORGAN TRANSPLANTS

A pioneering liver surgeon, Dr Mohamed Rela, has set several global milestones in his specialty, including entry into the Guinness Book of World Record, for a miraculous liver operation on a five-day-old infant. Even at 65, he is driven by the passion to make world-class treatment accessible and affordable to the common man. He built the super multi-specialty Rela Hospital in Chennai, which has emerged as a benchmark in excellence, especially in organ transplant. In an engaging conversation, Dr Rela, shared a wide spectrum about healthcare with Business Today.

Q What was the objective behind starting Rela Hospital, and as Chairman and Director, what are the initiatives that differentiates your hospital from the rest when it comes to medical infrastructure, clinical offerings, and patient care?

Rela Hospital, was built for a responsible social purpose. The objective was to provide an international level care to serve the local community. We want to remain local and that has been our ethos. And for that, we have built very high-end infrastructure, and I don't want to squander it only on affluent liver patients. I felt that our hospital should be accessible to all sections of the society that motivated me to make a conscious decision to build the facility in a not so posh locality of Chennai. That is the core business and that is the core specialty I am in.

Today, we do one of the largest number of close to 300 liver transplant in the country in a year. Patients, both nationally and internationally come not just for liver transplant, but also for the exemplary services in all other specialties such as pediatrics, general medicine, oncology, available in our hospital. Lung transplant is a recent addition to our portfolio. Our hospital is amongst the privileged few in India to have JCI accredited from the US. Another global achievement of our hospital is our unparalleled liver intensive care and infection control. This is the result of our focus on performing successful operations and good outcomes, which match

every parameter to that of UK. Our outcomes are fully audited and emphasis on intensive infection control, a salient feature of the hospital.

Q As chairman of a huge healthcare facility and in a country like India, where population continues to overwhelm the medical fraternity and the government, what according to you should be the measures taken by leaders like you to fix this existing healthcare gaps?

The best care can ultimately be provided through government sector, where all the facilities are made available. An example is the initiative of the Tamil Nadu government is a good, well-organized scheme for organ donation that has been replicated in most southern states, and Maharashtra as well, but yet to be adopted and implemented by northern states. The government scheme not only funds organ donation, but also organ transplant, under which Rs 22 lakhs is disbursed over a period of 2 years to such patients. Under an MOU based on PPP pattern, we almost do 60 transplants funded by the government, which means the superior infrastructure facility created by us is now available



to those who can afford the facility, and even by those who do not have the wherewithal. We help local doctors of government hospitals by our team of doctors in doing high-end surgeries and liver transplant, which has turned out to be a very successful collaborative initiative. My observation is that more private hospitals have to come up, but they largely cater to those with deep pockets resulting in huge discrepancy in the healthcare system in our country. Private sector can't fill the gap as it involves mobilizing huge investment, man power and machine. Having worked for 25 years in the NHS system of UK, I feel that their kind of treatment provided without any prejudice, free of cost, must be made available to the local population by our

